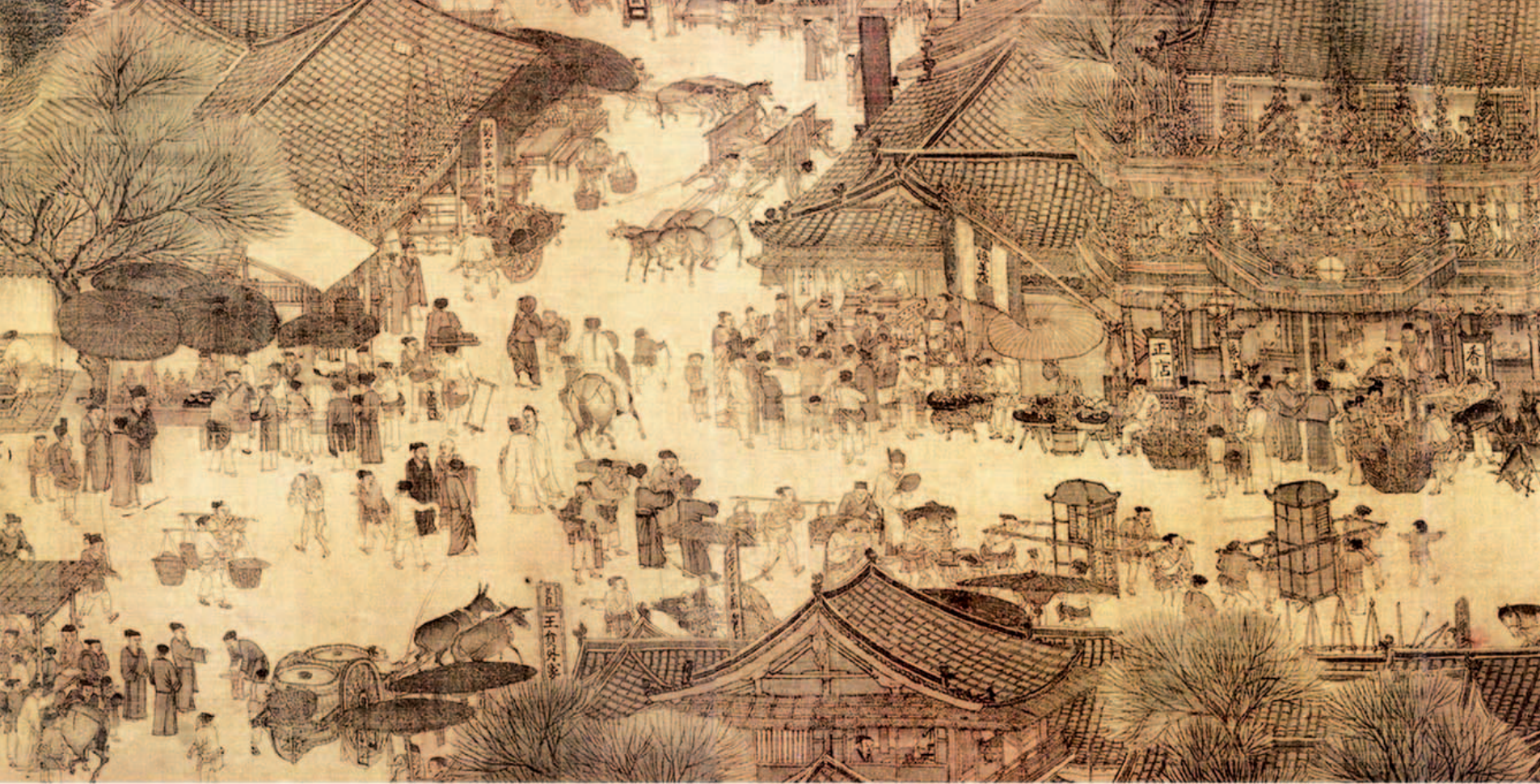




The Song Dynasty

The Song dynasty, established in 960 CE, reunited northern and southern China. Its extraordinary achievements in the arts and sciences outstripped developments in Europe at the time. However, aggression from the Jurchen people to the north gradually led to the surrender of northern China. The dynasty continued to rule in the south as the Southern Song, but was finally ousted by the Mongols in 1279.

BEFORE



FIVE DYNASTIES SCULPTURE

After the fall of the Tang in 907 CE, the empire disintegrated.

CHINA DIVIDED

Between the rule of the Tang and the Song dynasties, the **Qidan Liao** (see below) controlled the northeast of China, while the south fragmented into the **Ten Kingdoms**. Northern China came under the rule of a short succession of **Five Dynasties** until the reunification of north and south was achieved by the first emperor of the Song dynasty in 960 CE.

ALIEN RULE AND SINICIZATION

In 907 CE, the **nomadic Qidan people** founded the **Liao** dynasty. From 947 CE the Qidan Liao ruled over part of northern China. In the south of their territory, they **recruited Chinese officials** and **modeled their institutions on the Tang**.

Zhao Kuangyin was a general under the Later Zhou, the last of the Five Dynasties (see BEFORE). In 960 CE he usurped the throne and founded the Song dynasty, taking the imperial name Taizu. With a mixture of guile and persuasion he reunified the disparate states of China, apart from the territory held by the Qidan Liao (see BEFORE). Establishing his capital at Kaifeng, Taizu revived the successful administrative system of the Tang government (see pp.166–67), albeit in a modified form.

Some of the magnificence of the Tang era returned to Chinese culture during the Song dynasty. There was a renewed interest in literature and the decorative arts. Artists experimented with brush effects, and landscape, animal, and bird paintings were particularly prized. Song dynasty architecture was also renowned, particularly for its tall structures and pagodas, palaces, and temple roofs.

An economic revolution?

The administrative and technological advances made by the early Song led to economic prosperity. Instead of carrying around large sums of copper

coinage, Sichuan merchants began to trade in bills of exchange. These notes proved so successful that the government issued its first paper currency in 1024.

The country's infrastructure was also greatly improved during the Song period. The construction of an integrated system of internal waterways extended both the communications and trade networks. Large junks with four or six masts were developed, the magnetic compass was first used for navigation, and seafaring skills were improved. This led to an increase in maritime trade with the rest of East Asia, as well as with India and the east coast of Africa.

The innovations of the Song period affected China's population and urban growth. New methods of rice farming increased food output and allowed the population to double. Towns and cities grew along the main waterways and



Movable type

Between 1041 and 1048, Bi Sheng of Kaifeng invented the first printing system of its kind using clay characters held in wax within an iron frame.

along the southern coast, attracting at least ten percent of the population. Kaifeng became the greatest city in the world; in

the 12th century its levels of trade were nearly 50 percent more than those of London at the turn of the 18th century.

Examinations and officials

Under the Song, the examination system established by the Han dynasty (see pp.128–29) was revived and expanded. Quotas were set for the number of candidates who could pass, and steps were taken to guard against cheating and to ensure the anonymity of candidates. Over 140 candidates a year were awarded the *jinsshi*, the highest degree. In 1002, 14,500 men came to Kaifeng to take the imperial